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The Half Happy Formula



It's crunch time for the landmark Indo-US nuclear deal and the big question is whether the UPA Government will be able to push ahead with it? The steps ahead are that India has to sign an additional safe-

guards agreement with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), then the 45-member Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) has to vote to amend its rules and allow civilian nuclear trade with India. Finally the US Congress has to ratify the 123-bilateral Agreement between India and US. While the Government has already negotiated the safeguards agreement with the IAEA, it is waiting for the UPA-Left Coordination Committee to clear it. The Left parties wanted time to study the IAEA agreement and in the meanwhile have reiterated their stand that if the UPA Government goes ahead with the deal they would withdraw support to it.

If the Manmohan Singh Government defies the Left and sacrifices its political stability for the deal, there is no guarantee that the NSG would give its clearance without any harmful caveats and that the US Congress would ratify the 123 Agreement in its current form. Also in the run up to the elections, the Government would want the focus to remain on its pro-farmer, pro-poor, pro-minority and pro-reform agenda rather than divert attention on a deal that it is not sure much of the public comprehends. So dropping the Government for the deal isn't a viable option.



SAURABH SINGH

The way out is what I call the 'Half Happy Formula'. The Left has indicated that it has no objections to India entering into civilian nuclear trade with Russia and France. To do that, India still has to sign the IAEA safeguards agreement and get the NSG clearance. So the Government could seek clearance to go ahead with the IAEA safeguards with an assurance that it will not sign the Indo-US deal till the Left's conditions are met. Once India signs the IAEA safeguards the onus is on the George Bush administration to push the deal through the NSG and the US Congress. The US could do so by putting a caveat in the NSG that its members cannot have civilian nuclear trade with India till it signs the 123 Agreement with it.

Everyone then goes home half happy. The UPA Government can maintain it has kept its side of the deal, the Left can claim it has still blocked the US deal and the Bush administration can still take credit for making the breakthrough. The deal remains alive and the new governments in both countries would be presented with a fait accompli.

AT LOGGERHEADS:
Bhattal (left) and Singh



Fighting It Out

CHANDIGARH The Congress in Punjab seldom misses periodic spasms of factional infighting. But the recent spat between the state Congress President- Leader of Opposition Rajinder Kaur Bhattal and her old-time beté noire former chief minister Amarinder Singh has escalated into a vicious slugfest despite the high command's desperate efforts to make them bury the hatchet.

The public rally on Baisakhi at Talwandi Sabo in Malwa belt on April 14—orchestrated by the high command to project a semblance of unity in the state Congress—turned out to be an acrimonious show of strength between Bhattal and Singh. The rally was planned a day before the first meeting of an 11-member coordination committee set up by the high command to run the party affairs in Punjab in the wake of the Bhattal-Singh tussle. But not only did Singh publicly castigate Bhattal for 'hobnobbing' with the ruling Akalis, the Captain

defiantly boycotted the committee's meeting in Delhi and shot off a missive to Congress President Sonia Gandhi complaining that the panel was stuffed with Bhattal loyalists and meant to humiliate him.

Smarting under the ignominy of being sidelined since he lost power a year ago, Singh has upped the ante by declaring that he would have no truck with Bhattal and would independently work to strengthen the party. Bhattal hit back, accusing Singh of having "lost his mental balance".

According to political observers, Singh's desperate gambit is to pressure the high command to rehabilitate him in the AICC or the state Congress. But, given Sonia's less-than-cordial relationship with the erstwhile Patiala royal family—Singh's wife Preneet Kaur missed the bus in the recent expansion despite being a two-time MP from Patiala—the Captain may have bitten more than he could chew.

by Ramesh Vinayak